Microsoft Azure

Fuelling AI Innovation

Build and Scale Applications and Agents with Azure AI-Optimised Databases

How Azure SQL Database, Azure Database for PostgreSQL and Azure Cosmos DB help teams modernise the data layer, scale AI apps and agents and move from pilot to production with confidence. Based on Real Users of Microsoft Azure Databases.





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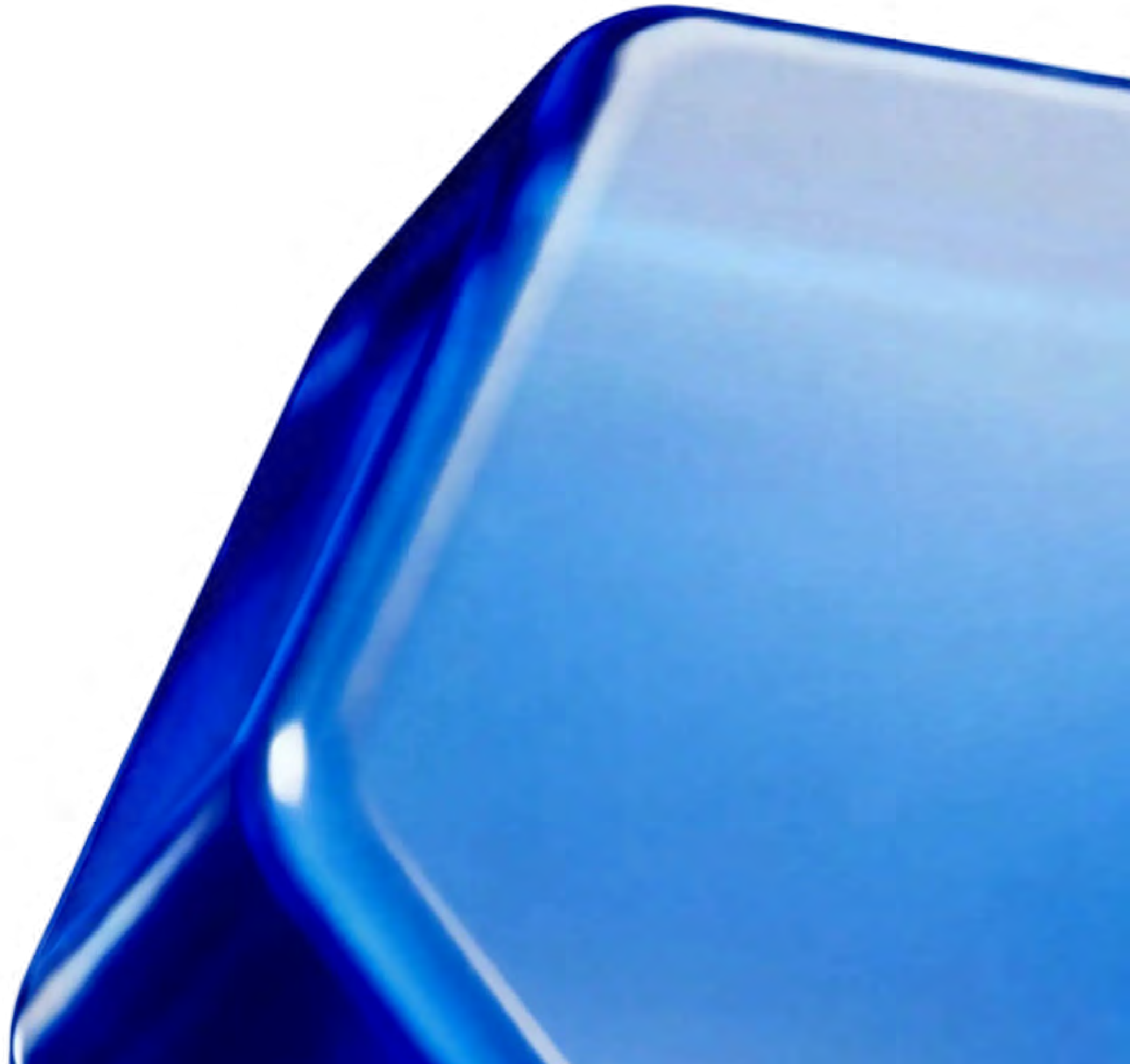
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Introduction: Data is the fuel for AI transformation



The Future of AI Starts with Databases

The next barrier to AI value is not model access; it is whether enterprise data platforms can deliver trusted, governed, low-latency data to AI applications without compromising security, resilience or sovereignty.

AI has moved from experimentation to execution. 86% of business leaders believe AI will be critical to maintaining or growing revenue in the years ahead.[1]

At the same time, users are demanding more intelligent, more intelligent, data-driven applications. They expect natural language interactions, personalised recommendations and real-time responses that adapt instantly at global scale.

Taken together, the needs of businesses and users are defining what databases must deliver in the AI era.

Databases as AI Enablers

AI applications change what is required from a database. Beyond storing information, databases must become AI enablers: ingesting massive and unpredictable workloads, delivering low-latency access to fresh data and supporting vector embeddings, semantic search and similarity matching. They must also provide the compliance, privacy and reliability needed to use sensitive data in AI training and inference. This convergence of operational and AI capabilities marks a fundamental shift in what traditional databases were designed to deliver.

The Challenge for Developers

Traditional databases fall short where it matters most: scalability, performance and AI-readiness. Developers need platforms that can auto-scale to meet unpredictable demand, sustain high performance under heavy loads and natively support advanced AI workloads such as vector search and retrieval augmented generation (RAG). They also need the flexibility to easily integrate emerging tools and services. Without these capabilities, teams struggle to deliver the intelligent, high-performing applications that users expect.

The challenges go beyond the technical limitations of traditional databases. For developers, there is a clear impact on their day-to-day work. Building AI-driven applications often means juggling multiple systems, each with its own APIs and management overhead. That complexity slows iteration, makes debugging harder and increases the risk of errors in production.

Teams lose time wiring together infrastructure instead of building the features that matter to users. Knowledge sharing and collaboration also suffer when every project requires different tools and workarounds.

The result: developers face mounting friction just as the demand for AI-powered applications is accelerating.



1 Furlonger, David. Gartner. April 25, 2025.

Azure Databases: Optimised for AI

That's exactly the gap Microsoft Azure databases are designed to close. Azure databases are optimised for AI workloads – combining operational reliability with advanced AI capabilities in a single platform.

With elasticity to handle unpredictable workloads, low-latency responses and built-in vector operations, Azure databases give organisations the scale and intelligence needed to power next-generation AI applications. They also integrate seamlessly with services across Azure – including Microsoft Foundry and Microsoft Fabric – so data can flow wherever it's needed for training, inference and analytics. For enterprise AI, speed must be paired with trust: the data platform needs to scale retrieval and inference while keeping sensitive data governed, resilient and aligned to regional or sovereignty requirements.

For developers, the advantage is simplicity. Instead of wiring together multiple services, they can rely on databases with native support for semantic search and direct integration with Foundry products like Azure OpenAI.

This reduces pipeline complexity, accelerates iteration and helps teams implement sophisticated AI patterns while following safe and responsible AI practices – without the overhead of building custom infrastructure.



For example, developers can build RAG applications without stitching together separate systems. With unified APIs, they can generate embeddings, store them alongside source documents and run similarity searches – all within the same database environment. The result is faster development and a streamlined workflow for intelligent applications.

This AI-first design allows teams to go beyond prototypes and deliver real AI applications in production – whether building global-scale conversational agents, personalised recommendation systems or predictive analytics that adapt in real time.

The central question for every team – whether they're building AI applications or setting AI strategy – is clear: is your database optimised for AI? Backed by real customer testimonials, the following sections explore how Azure Cosmos DB, Azure Database for PostgreSQL and Azure SQL Database each answer that question, providing the foundation for developers and enterprises to build and scale the next generation of intelligent, AI-powered applications.

Microsoft Sovereign Cloud

The most comprehensive set of sovereign solutions across AI, productivity, security and cloud platform.

Our approach is simple – digital sovereignty is foundational to our cloud and services, delivered through a well-governed combination of technical, contractual and operational controls and because every workload and every organisation has different levels of sensitivity and criticality, sovereignty requirements are adaptable to the needs of each customer.

The Microsoft Sovereign Cloud brings together AI, productivity, security and cloud workloads to span public, hybrid and disconnected environments so customers can apply the right level of control, capability and compliance based on the sensitivity and criticality of each workload rather than relying on a single deployment model.

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Build AI apps faster with open-source flexibility on Azure Database for PostgreSQL

Azure Database for PostgreSQL appeals to developers who prefer open-source tools while requiring enterprise-level reliability and support.

Open-Source Familiarity with Cloud-Scale Performance

Azure Database for PostgreSQL gives us greater performance capabilities and flexibility, enabling smaller teams to do more – especially when managing large numbers of databases.

This managed service helps eliminate operational overhead while preserving PostgreSQL's flexibility and extensibility.

Native Extension Support for AI Workloads

PostgreSQL's extension ecosystem helps AI developers add specialised capabilities without migrating to different platforms. Extensions like pgvector and pg_diskann and VSCode provide native vector operations, while other extensions support time-series analysis, geospatial processing and statistical functions essential for AI applications and agents.

This extensibility benefits teams building AI applications requiring multiple data processing paradigms.

Ease of Setup & Cost-Effectiveness

For AI developers working on experimental projects or startups with limited budgets, PostgreSQL provides a cost-effective entry point. The flexible pricing model enables teams to start small and scale based on application success.

> Azure Database for PostgreSQL and pgvector helped the team store operational data as vectors for AI agents, accelerating customer-focused innovation.

Sathish Palanisamy

Staff Data Engineer, transportation company, 10,001+ Employees

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> PostgreSQL and JSONB helped the team move quickly from proof of concept to production while supporting structured and schemaless data.

Scott Rupprecht

Lead Software Engineer, retailer, 5,001–10,000 Employees

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Intelligent Applications with PostgreSQL and pgvector

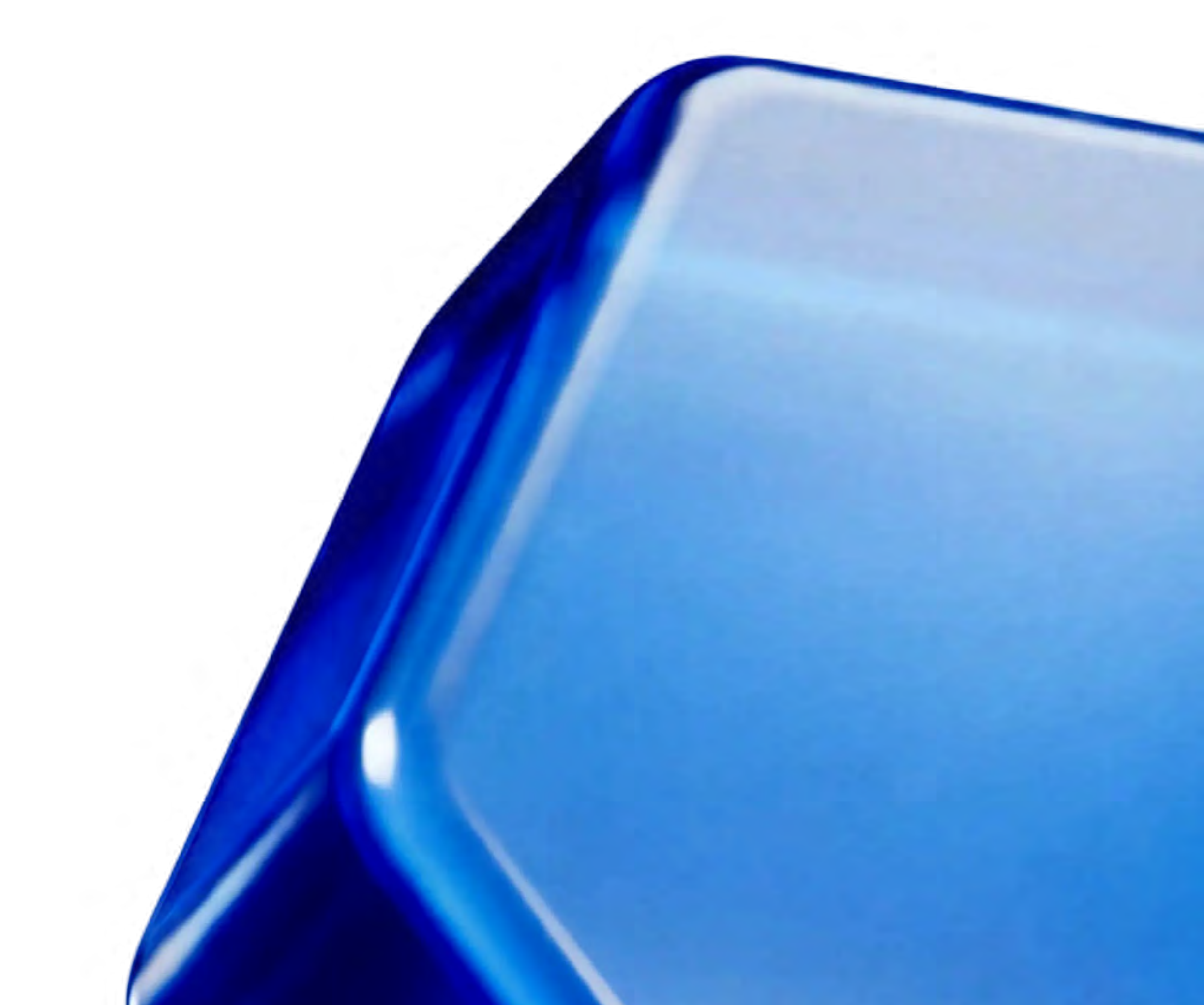
The pgvector extension transforms PostgreSQL into a vector-capable database while maintaining full SQL compatibility. AI developers can store vector embeddings alongside relational data, enabling applications that combine structured queries with semantic search operations. This hybrid approach is useful for applications requiring both precise filtering and similarity matching, such as product recommendation systems that consider user preferences and product attributes. The PostgreSQL approach to AI development is particularly appealing to teams that value incremental adoption over wholesale platform changes.

Rather than requiring developers to learn entirely new systems, PostgreSQL with Azure's managed service allows teams to gradually introduce AI capabilities while maintaining their existing SQL skills and development patterns. This incremental path often accelerates AI adoption in enterprises where PostgreSQL expertise already exists.



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Modernise mission-critical SQL workloads for secure, scalable AI apps



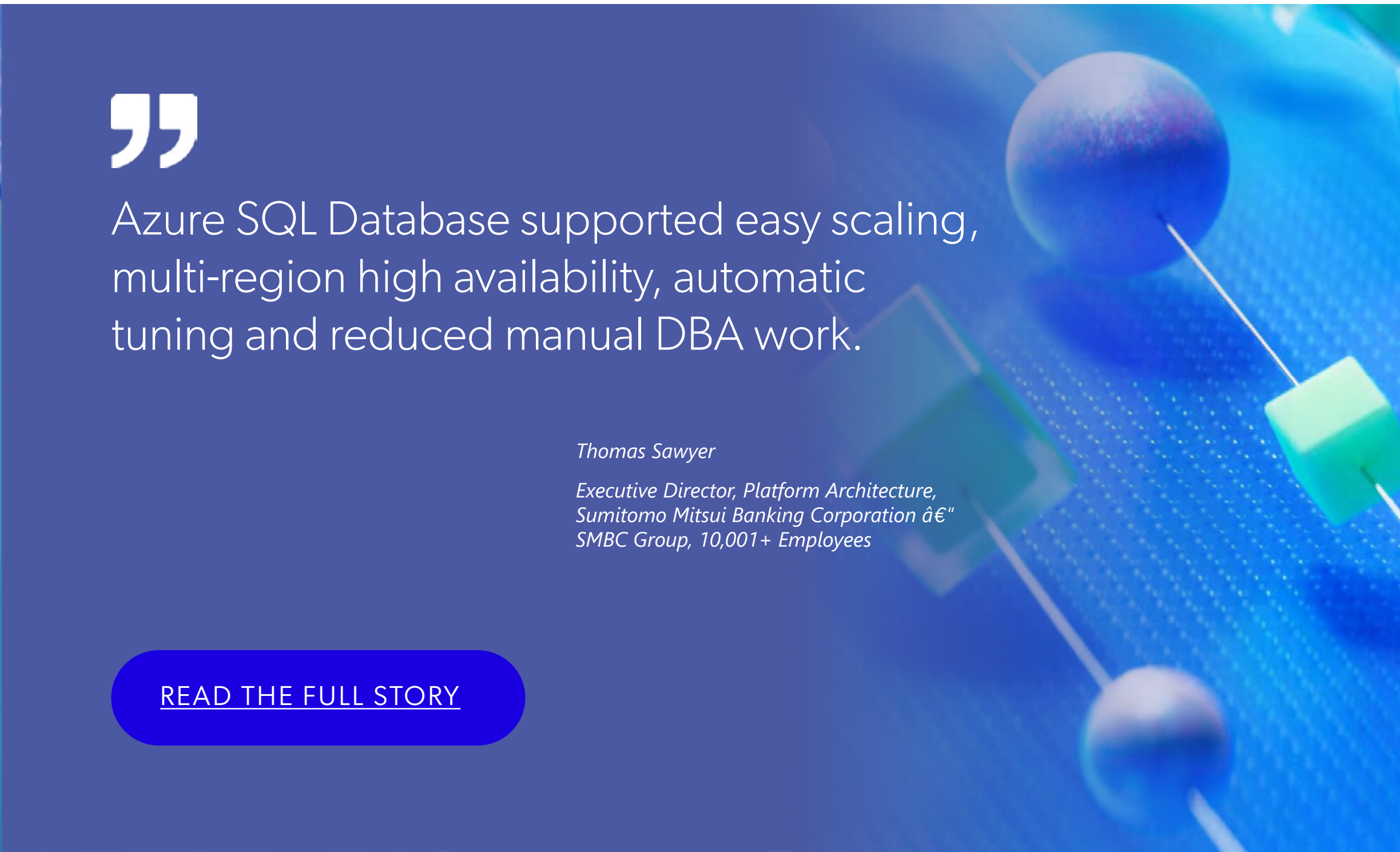
Azure SQL Database is the relational cloud database for optimising AI application performance and accelerating time to market. Built on the same engine as SQL Server, it enables developers to build intelligent applications using familiar tools and frameworks. Any app, any architecture, any scale – serving 1B+ inferences/day.

Familiar SQL Server Experience with Azure SQL

Cloud-Native Flexibility Azure SQL Database maintains full T-SQL compatibility while adding cloud-native features like automatic scaling and global distribution. Developers can build on what they already know, accelerating the integration of AI capabilities into existing enterprise applications.

Azure SQL Database Hyperscale extends this foundation with the performance and scalability to support the most demanding, mission-critical applications – including AI workloads. With support for up to 100 TB of storage and the ability to scale compute and storage independently, Hyperscale is ideally suited for the massive volumes of data AI models generate and consume, ensuring applications remain responsive and efficient at any scale.

Teams can use Hyperscale to separate compute and storage growth, apply automatic tuning for query performance, use Microsoft Entra ID and Azure Key Vault for governed access and connect application data to Azure AI services for real-time interference without moving sensitive data into disconnected stores.



> Azure SQL Database supported easy scaling, multi-region high availability, automatic tuning and reduced manual DBA work.

Thomas Sawyer

Executive Director, Platform Architecture, Sumitomo Mitsui Banking Corporation â€" SMBC Group, 10,001+ Employees

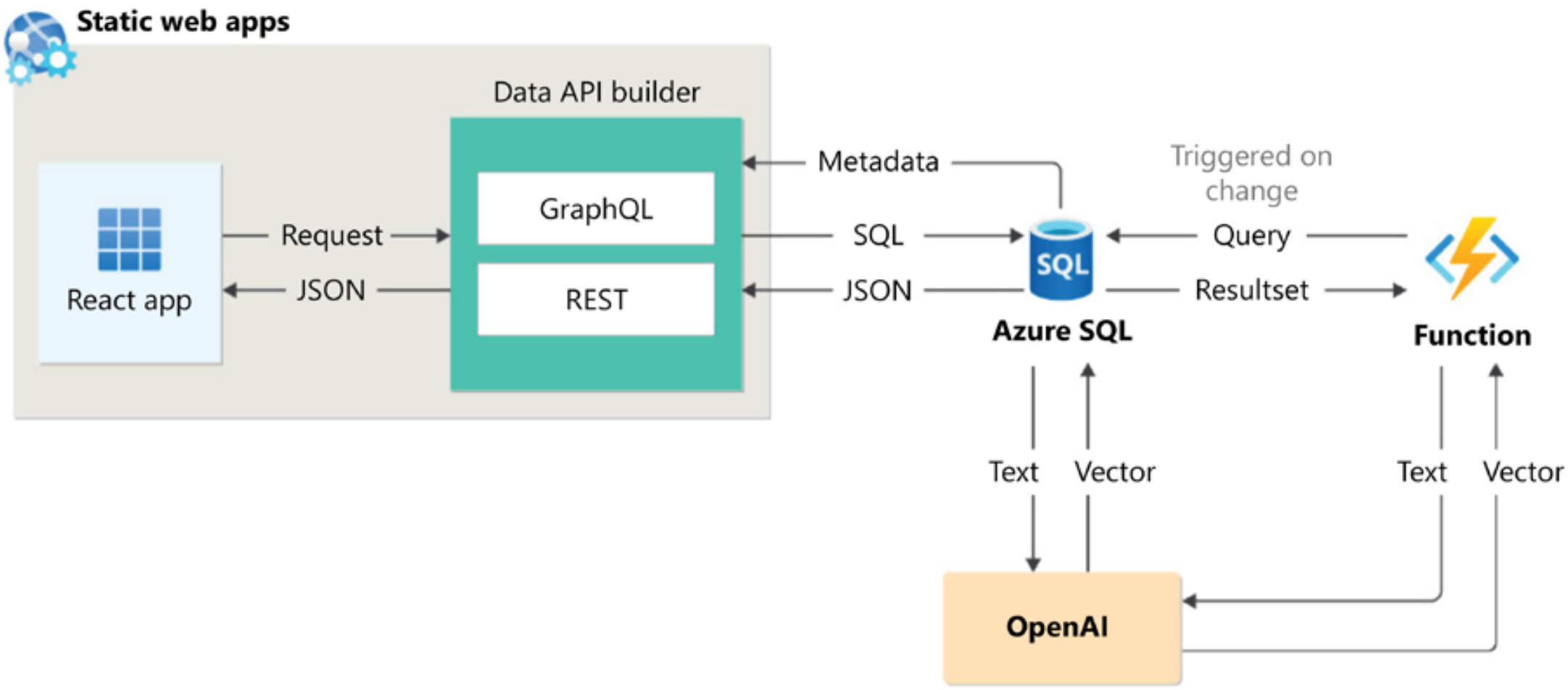
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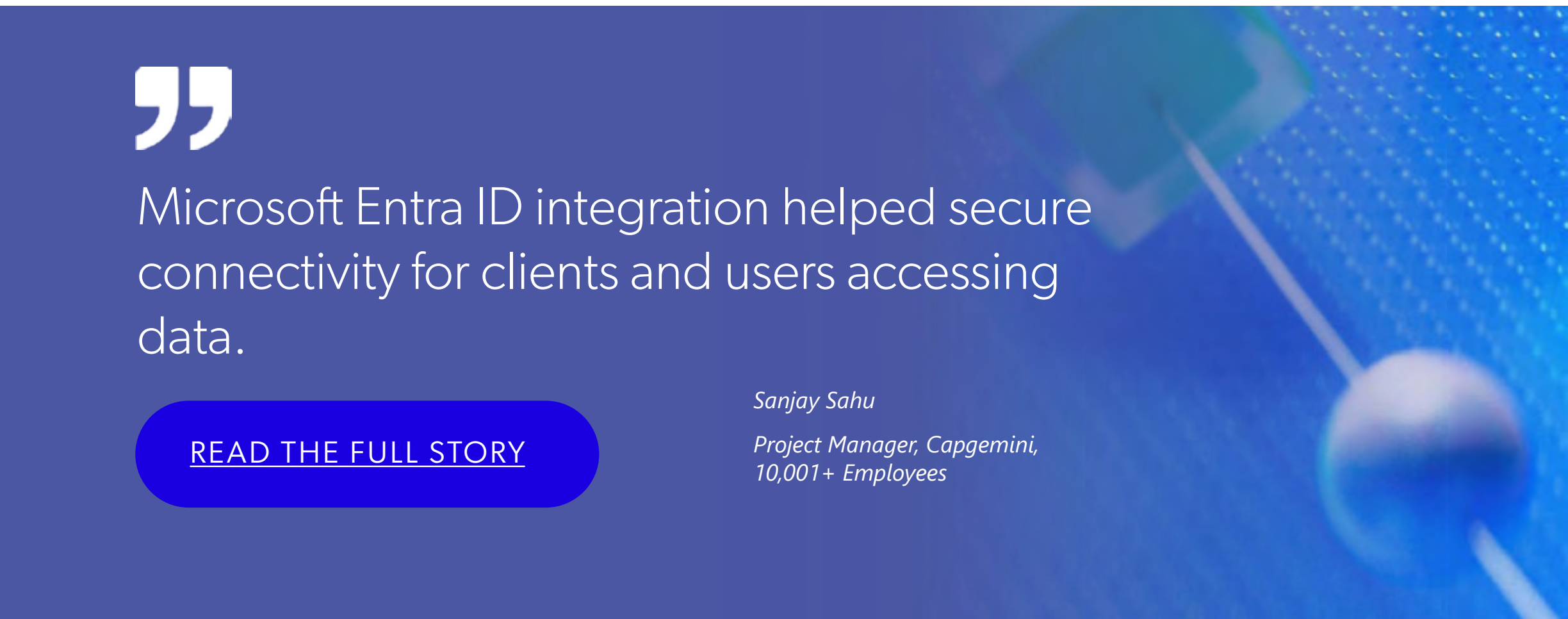
Native AI integration for building intelligent applications

Azure SQL Database natively integrates with Foundry Tools, enabling key patterns for building intelligent applications with minimal overhead. Developers can build RAG applications that improve large language models by pulling in relevant data from external sources to give more accurate responses. Through external REST endpoint invocation, SQL stored procedures can securely call services such as Azure OpenAI or Azure AI Search, allowing developers to enrich applications with natural language processing, semantic search and other AI workloads.

Azure SQL Database also supports in-database vector operations through a native vector data type, enabling similarity search across embeddings stored alongside relational data.

Developers can run ONNX machine learning models directly within Azure SQL Database, reducing data movement and enabling real-time inference scenarios. Trained models can be deployed as stored procedures or functions, supporting SQL-based AI applications. This is particularly beneficial for applications requiring real-time scoring, such as fraud detection systems that evaluate transactions immediately upon entry.





Microsoft Entra ID integration helped secure connectivity for clients and users accessing data.

READ THE FULL STORY

Sanjay Sahu

Project Manager, Capgemini, 10,001+ Employees

Availability for Regulated Environments

Enterprise AI applications are often used in regulated industries, where strict security and compliance is required. Azure SQL Database provides developers with built-in enterprise-grade security features, such as encryption, access controls, ledger capabilities and audit logging.

In addition, Azure SQL Database's built-in high availability ensures AI applications maintain consistent service levels during peak usage or system maintenance.

Security and High Powerful Integration with Analytics

Azure SQL Database's integration with Microsoft Fabric and Power BI enables developers to build comprehensive intelligence platforms that combine operational AI with analytical insights. Azure SQL Database also integrates with Microsoft Power Platform, which offers no-code/low-code tools for building apps, visualising data, automating workflows, creating external-facing websites and building AI agents. With these integrations, developers can deliver applications that support both real-time AI processing and historical analysis and reporting. The strength of Azure SQL Database for AI applications lies in its ability to bridge traditional enterprise data management with contemporary AI requirements. By unifying relational data with vector similarity search and direct integration to Foundry Tools, developers can ground AI experiences in enterprise data without moving information across multiple platforms.

> Azure Policies, vulnerability scanning and database setup controls helped the team advance a well-managed Azure SQL environment.

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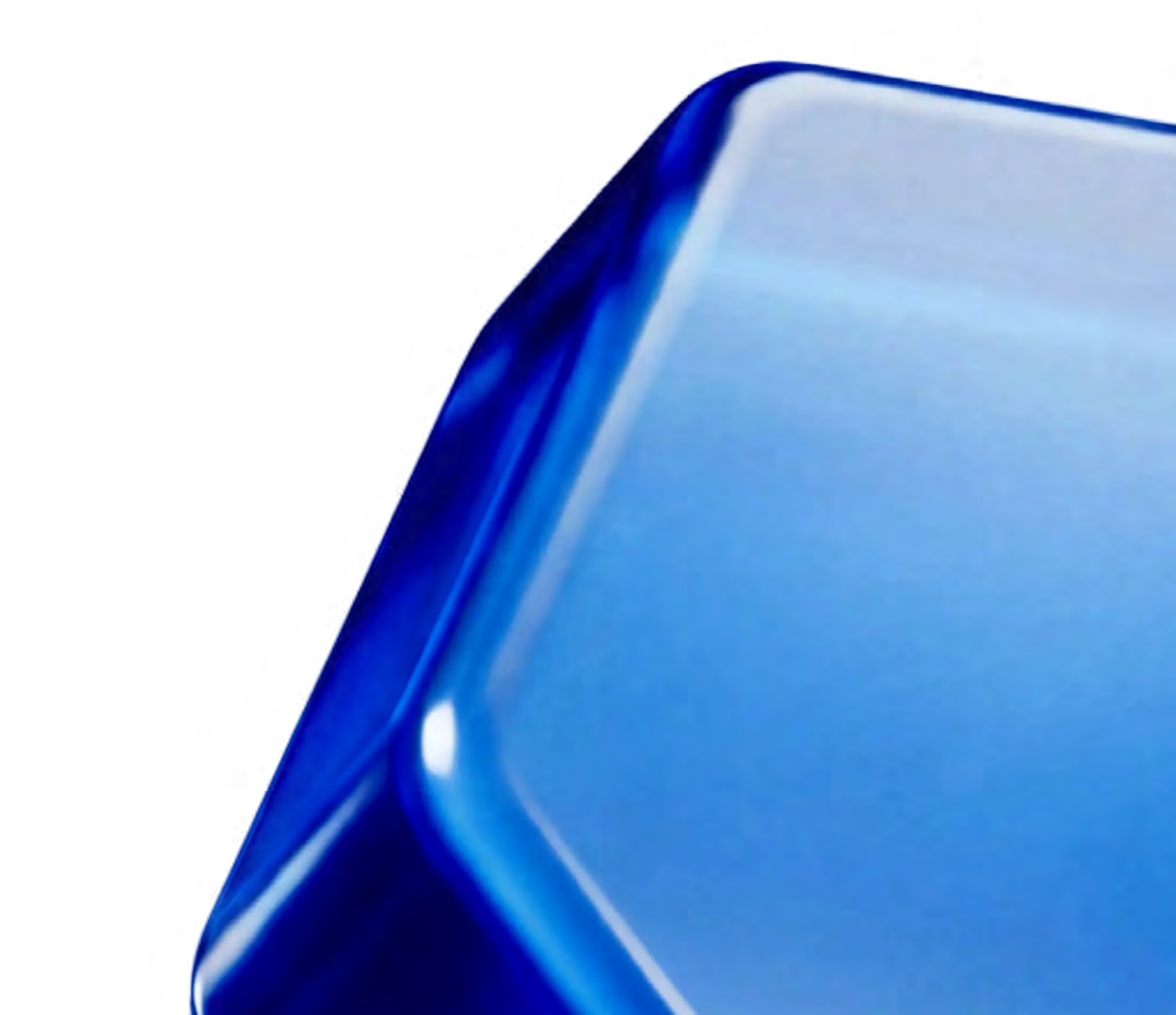
Kamil Konderak

Senior Cloud Architect, manufacturing company, 5,001-10,000 Employees

For teams operating in regulated industries or large enterprises with established SQL Server investments, Azure SQL Database provides a pathway to AI innovation that doesn't require abandoning existing skills, compliance frameworks or integration patterns. The result is often faster AI adoption with lower risk compared to greenfield approaches.

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Scale real-time AI agents globally with Azure Cosmos DB



For globally distributed AI applications, the database layer must support low-latency retrieval, elastic scale and regional control so teams can serve users reliably while respecting data residency and governance requirements.

Scalability & Performance: Auto-Scaling, Global Distribution, Low-Latency Reads/Writes

Azure Cosmos DB's automatic scaling capabilities adjust to unpredictable AI workload patterns – from sudden inference request spikes to batch processing for model training Azure Cosmos DB gives AI applications global reach, scaling across regions while preserving millisecond A latency and reliable consistency.

Millisecond response times are essential for real-time AI applications like chatbots, recommendation engines and fraud detection systems that must respond to user interactions immediately.

AI Enablement: Built-in Vector Search for RAG Applications

Azure Cosmos DB's integrated vector storage and automatic indexing reduces the need to maintain separate vector databases, simplifying application architecture while supporting sophisticated AI patterns. The platform supports high-dimensional vector operations, full-text and semantic search and traditional document queries within the same API calls.

Developers building RAG applications can store documents, generate embeddings through Azure OpenAI in Foundry Models and execute semantic searches without managing data synchronisation between multiple systems.

> The team chunked and vectorised public documentation to support an internal question-and-answer experience.

Aditya Jitendra Kshirsagar

Software Engineer, tech supplier, 501-1,000 Employees

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> API access simplified application interaction, while convenient scaling supported changing workload needs.

Kunal Karn

System Administrator Technology Services Engineer, retailer, 10,001+ Employees

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> Global distribution and low-latency data access supported operational data across regions.

Panchanan Turuk

Full Stack Developer, tech services company, 5,001-10,000 Employees

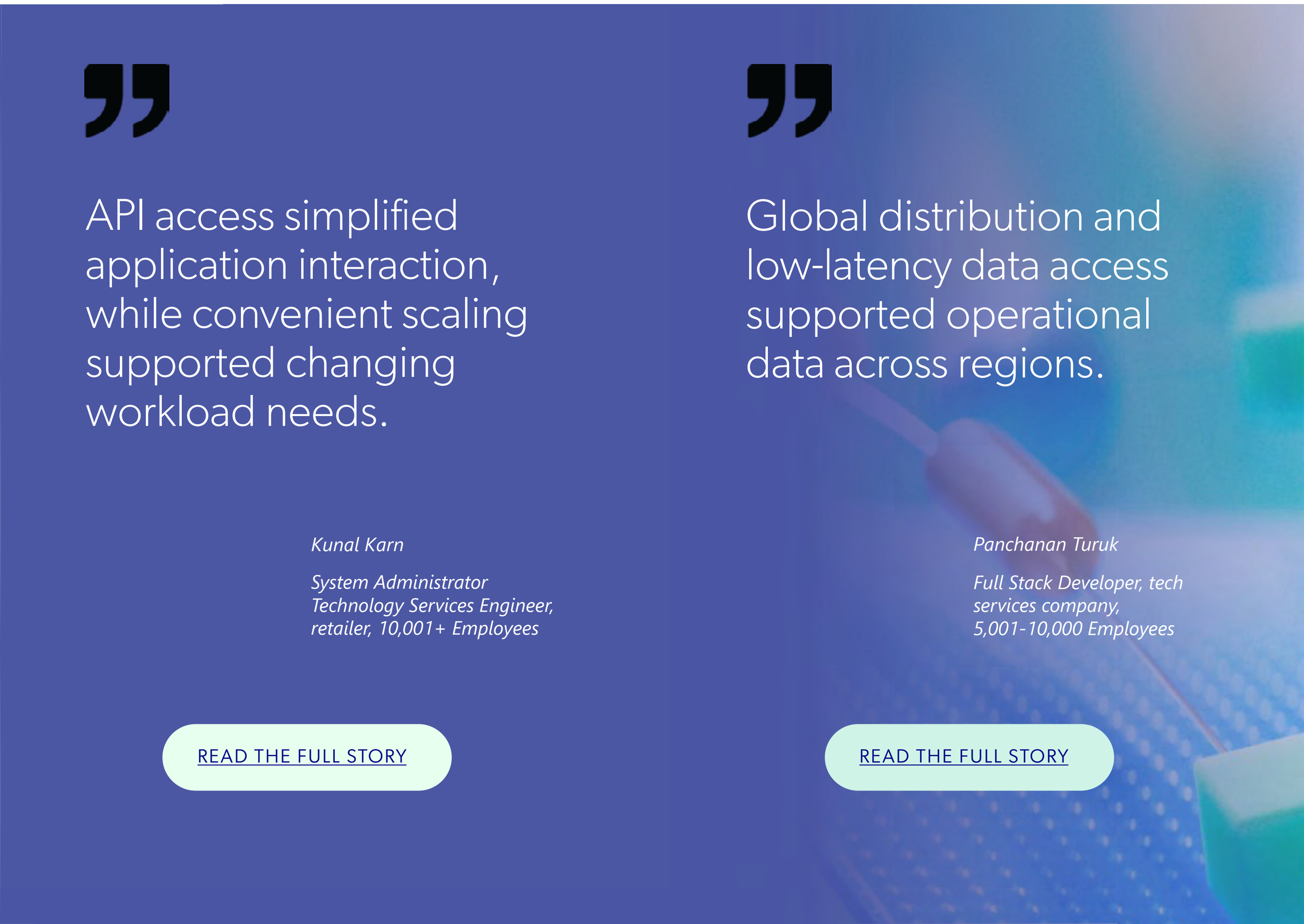
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Developer Agility: Build Faster with Familiar Tools

Azure Cosmos DB provides developers with multiple API options, including a native JSON document (NoSQL) API built for millisecond read/writes and integrated vector search.

Developers also have the option to use the vCore-based MongoDB-compatible API, powered by the open-source DocumentDB project. Teams can use familiar programming patterns while accessing advanced AI capabilities, reducing the learning curve for migrating applications or integrating AI features. Comprehensive SDK support for languages such as Python, node.JS and Java enables developers to work with their preferred languages and frameworks, accelerating prototyping and application development.

Vector indexing optimisations help similarity searches execute efficiently even with millions of embeddings, supporting production-scale AI applications without performance degradation. Azure Cosmos DB for NoSQL supports multiple vector index types for billion-scale search. DiskANN in Azure Cosmos DB for NoSQL delivers high-speed and highly accurate large-scale vector search by storing most of the index on disk instead of in memory, enabling low latency and cost-efficiency for AI workloads.



> API access simplified application interaction, while convenient scaling supported changing workload needs.

Kunal Karn

System Administrator Technology Services Engineer, retailer, 10,001+ Employees

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> Global distribution and low-latency data access supported operational data across regions.

Panchanan Turuk

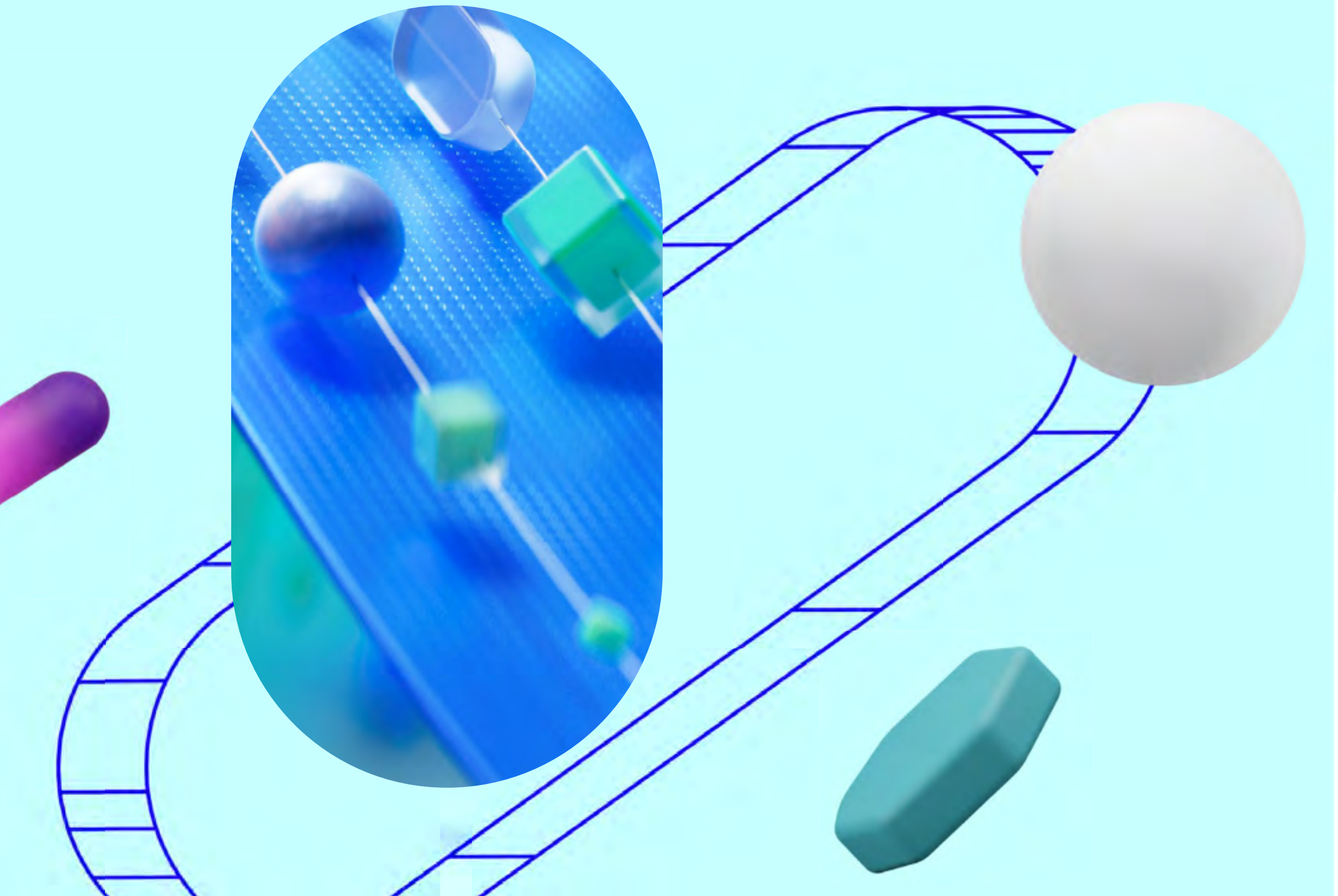
Full Stack Developer, tech services company, 5,001-10,000 Employees

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Time to Market: Accelerating MVP Development

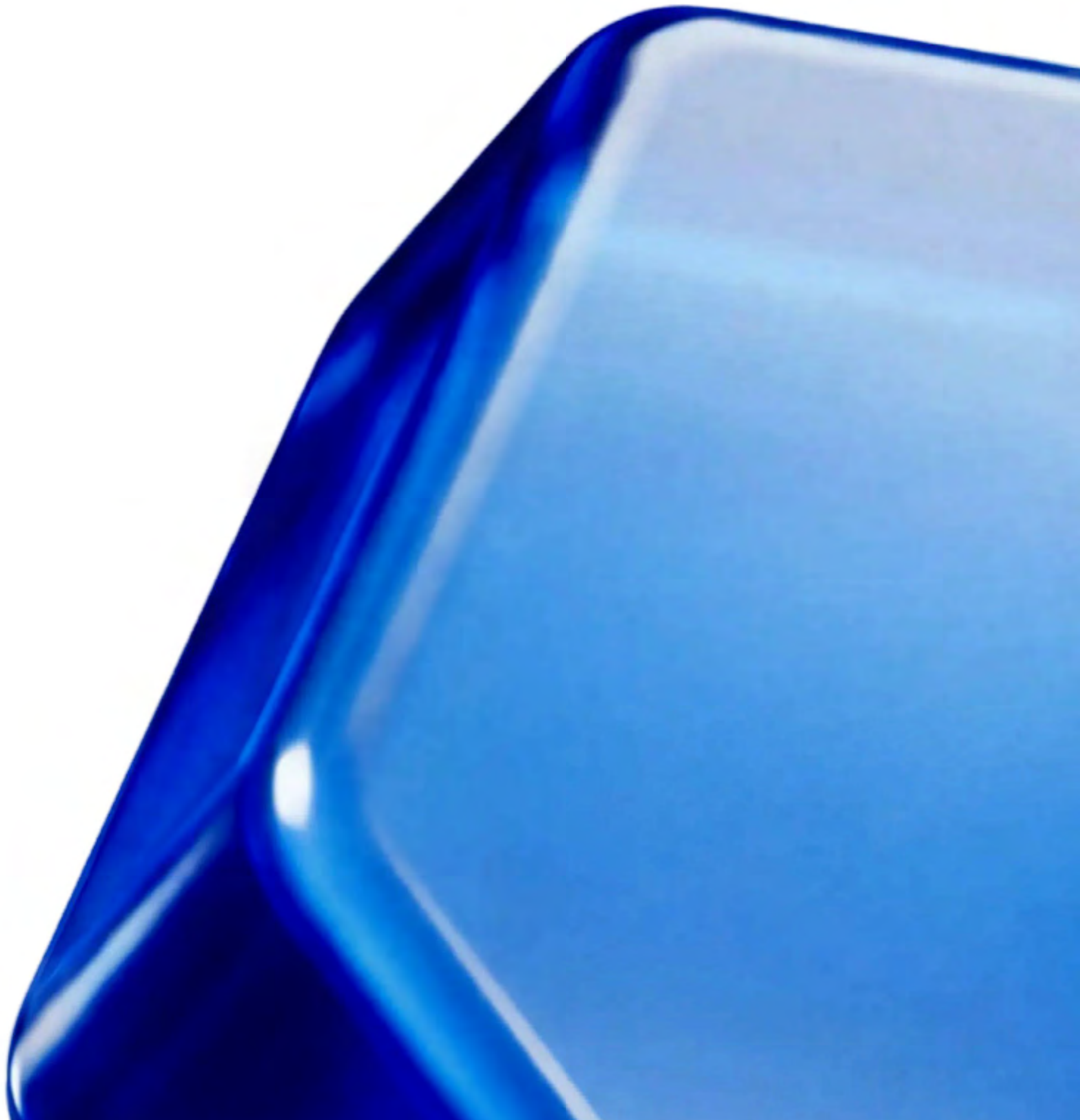
Azure Cosmos DB's managed service model reduces infrastructure management overhead. Developers can focus on building AI features rather than managing database clusters, replication and scaling.

Serverless options are particularly ideal for AI applications with unpredictable usage patterns, combining instant scalability with consumption-based efficiency.



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AI Application Patterns with Azure Databases



RAG with Azure Cosmos DB and Azure OpenAI

RAG is one of the most popular AI application patterns, enabling developers to ground large language models in specific domain knowledge. Azure Cosmos DB's integrated vector search simplifies RAG implementation by reducing the need for separate vector databases.

Developers can store documents in Azure Cosmos DB, generate embeddings through Azure OpenAI, store embeddings alongside original documents and execute similarity searches for relevant context in language model prompts. AI agents are another popular AI use case. To operate efficiently, agents often need a persistent, high-performance memory and knowledge store. Azure Cosmos DB plays that role by storing and retrieving the structured, unstructured and vectorised data agents use to reason, plan and act.



> Autoscale and dependable low-latency access helped the organisation operate efficiently as demand changed.

Patrick Chanez
COO & CTO, inexto,
51-200 Employees

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AI-Powered Personalisation Using Azure Database for PostgreSQL and Vector Extensions

Personalisation systems require databases to handle both user behavioural data and product/content embeddings for similarity matching.

Azure Database for PostgreSQL with pgvector enables developers to build recommendation engines combining SQL-based filtering with vector similarity search. This allows applications to filter items based on business rules (availability, pricing, category) and then rank results using semantic similarity to user preferences.

Predictive Analytics with Azure SQL Database and T-SQLAI Integration

Enterprise applications often require predictive capabilities integrated directly into operational workflows. Azure SQL Database enables developers to deploy machine learning models as stored procedures for real-time scoring within transactional applications.

This pattern is useful for applications like fraud detection, dynamic pricing or inventory optimisation that make predictions based on real-time operational data.

> Azure SQL capabilities supported operational workloads and application performance within familiar SQL development patterns.

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Corey Carter

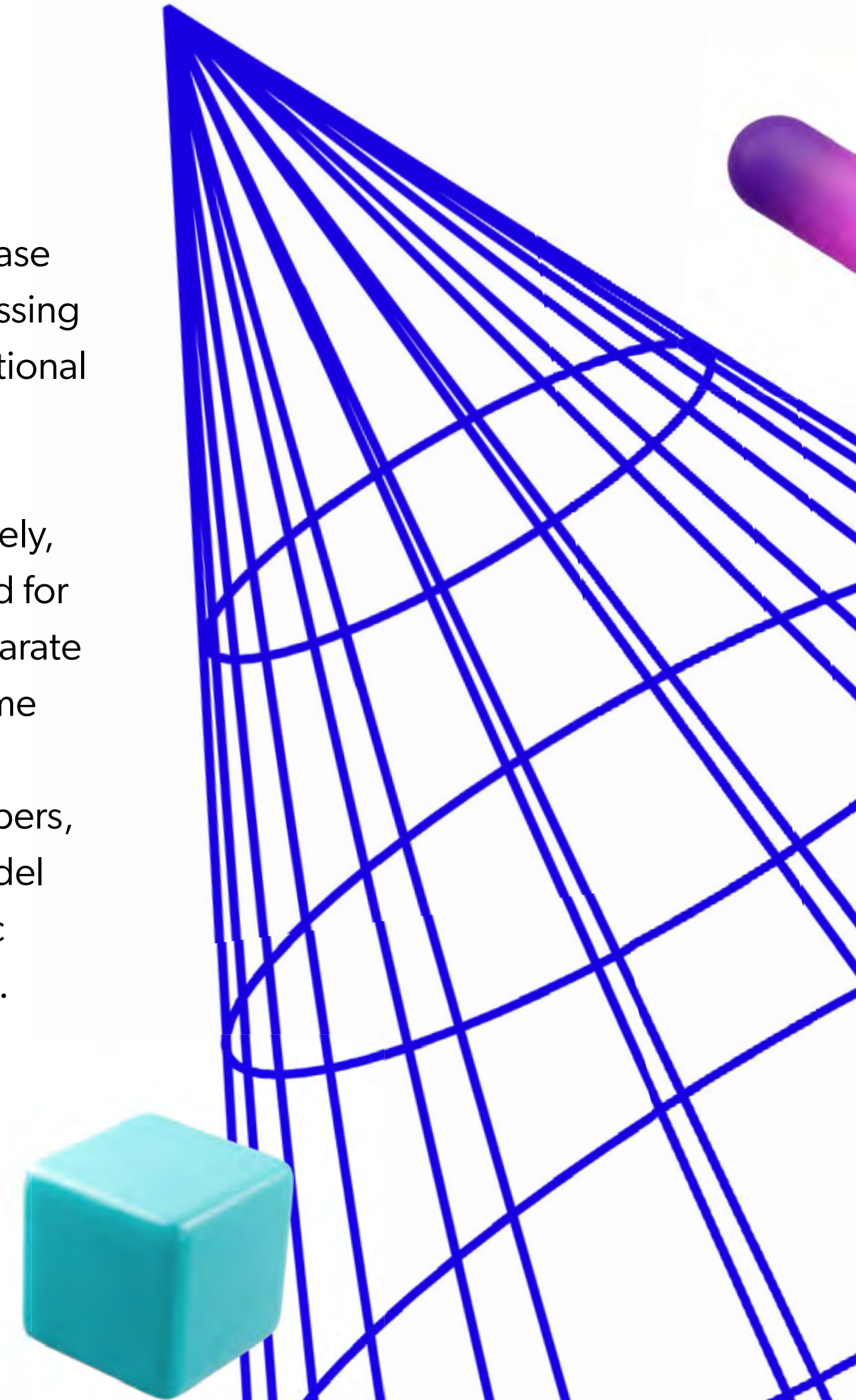
Database Administrator, energy/utilities company, 1,001-5,000 Employees

Hybrid Architectures with Event-Driven and Streaming AI

AI applications often combine multiple databases and processing patterns to handle different aspects of intelligent systems.

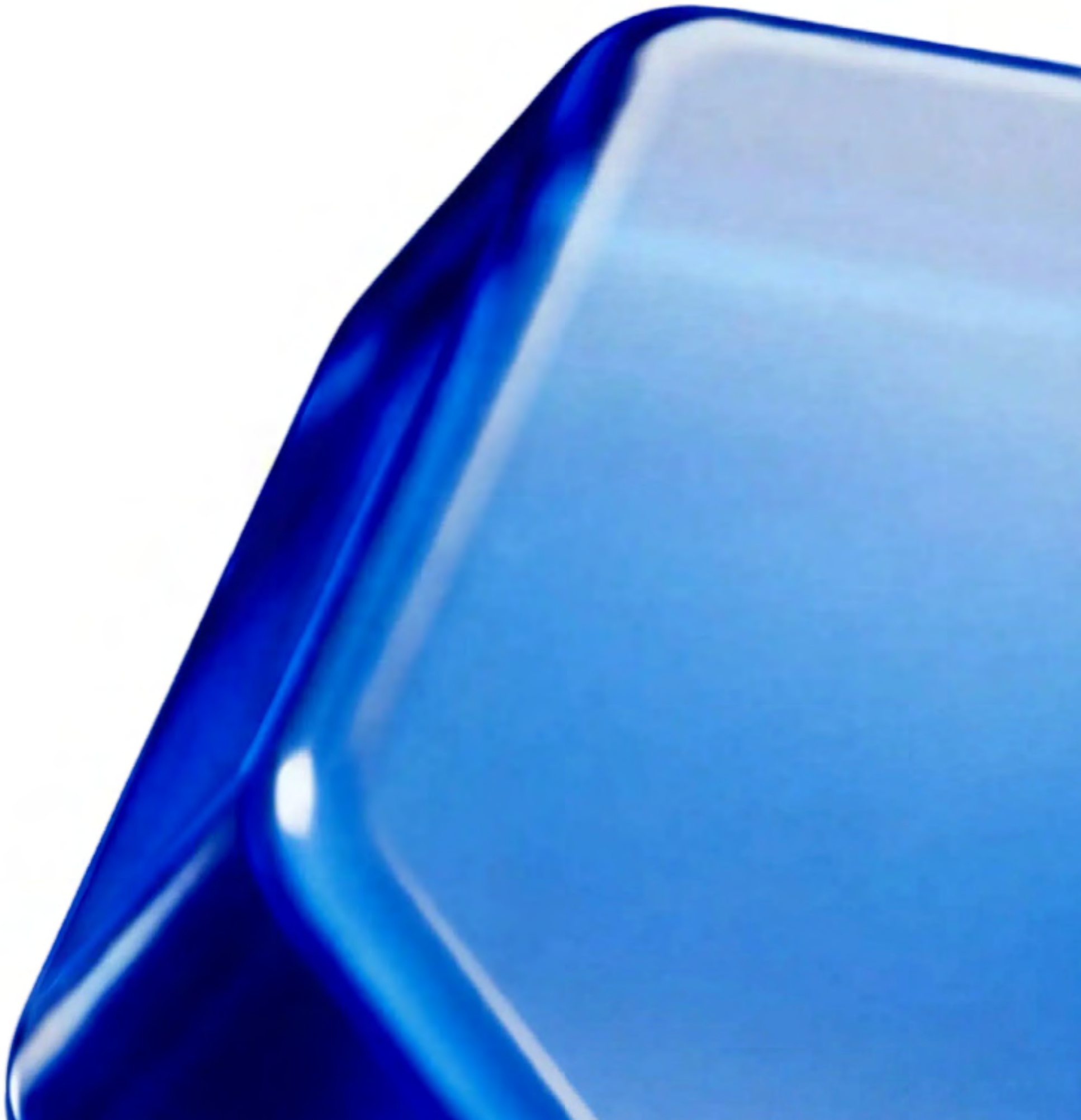
Developers can use Azure Cosmos DB's change feed to trigger AI processing pipelines, Azure Database for PostgreSQL for analytical processing and Azure SQL Database for operational intelligence.

By supporting each workload natively, Azure databases eliminate the need for complex integrations between separate systems, reducing development time and operational overhead while increasing reliability. For AI developers, this means more time spent on model development and application logic rather than infrastructure plumbing.



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Developer Experience: Build Fast, Scale Faster



The Importance of Choosing the Right Database

The choice of database platform fundamentally shapes how AI developers approach their daily work. Beyond individual database features, the development workflow – from initial prototype to production deployment – varies significantly across database platforms, affecting everything from debugging complexity to team collaboration patterns.

Relational databases store data in tables with rows and columns, whereas NoSQL databases store data as JSON documents. Depending on the database they choose, developers either develop against a fixed schema or manage the data structure within the application code (schemaless development).

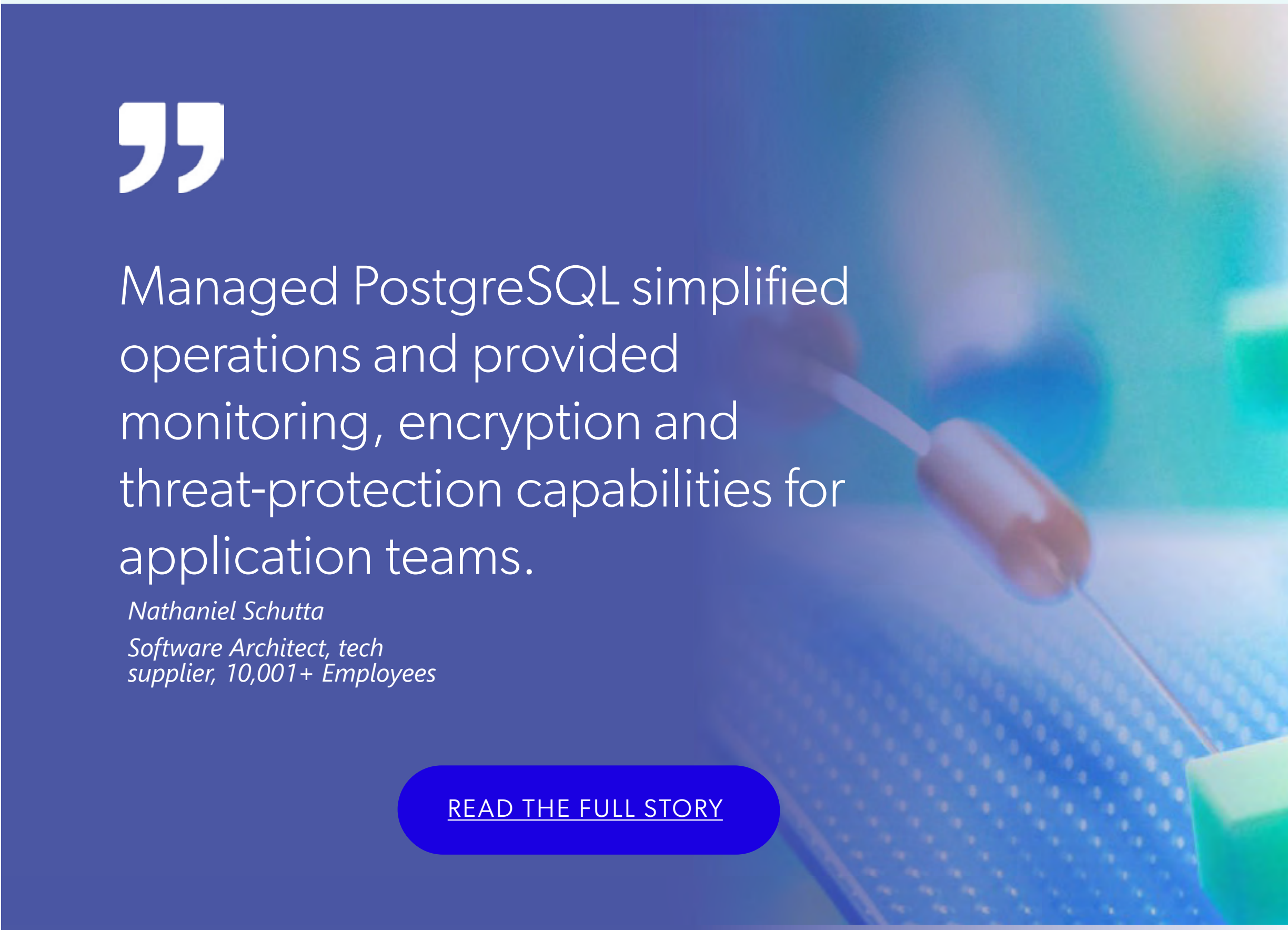
Microsoft SDKs are available for Azure Cosmos DB, Azure Database for PostgreSQL and Azure SQL Database. The following Kinectify quote refers to Microsoft SDKs built for Azure Cosmos DB, but similar results are possible with Azure Database for PostgreSQL or AzureSQL Database.



Debugging and Observability in AI Applications

AI applications present unique debugging challenges that are often not addressed by traditional database tooling. Vector similarity results, embedding generation performance and AI model inference bottlenecks require specialised observability approaches that vary significantly between platforms.

Azure Database for PostgreSQL's extensive logging and query analysis tools help developers understand both SQL query performance and vector search behaviour within the same debugging session. This unified troubleshooting experience is particularly beneficial for AI applications that combine traditional queries with semantic search operations.



> Managed PostgreSQL simplified operations and provided monitoring, encryption and threat-protection capabilities for application teams.

Nathaniel Schutta

Software Architect, tech supplier, 10,001+ Employees

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Team Collaboration and Knowledge Transfer

The learning curve for different database platforms affects not only individual productivity, but also team dynamics and knowledge sharing.

Azure SQL Database's familiar tooling enables teams to onboard new developers quickly, while Azure Cosmos DB's multiple API options allow teams with different backgrounds to contribute effectively to the same project.

Development Methodology Alignment

Different Azure databases align with different development methodologies and team structures. Agile teams building AI prototypes often gravitate toward Azure Cosmos DB's schema flexibility, while enterprise teams with established DevOps practices may prefer Azure SQL Database's integration with existing CI/CD pipelines. Both emerging and established developer teams looking for the familiarity, flexibility and extensibility of open source tools may favour Azure Database for PostgreSQL.



Moving from PostgreSQL on virtual machines to a managed service streamlined application development and automated deployments.

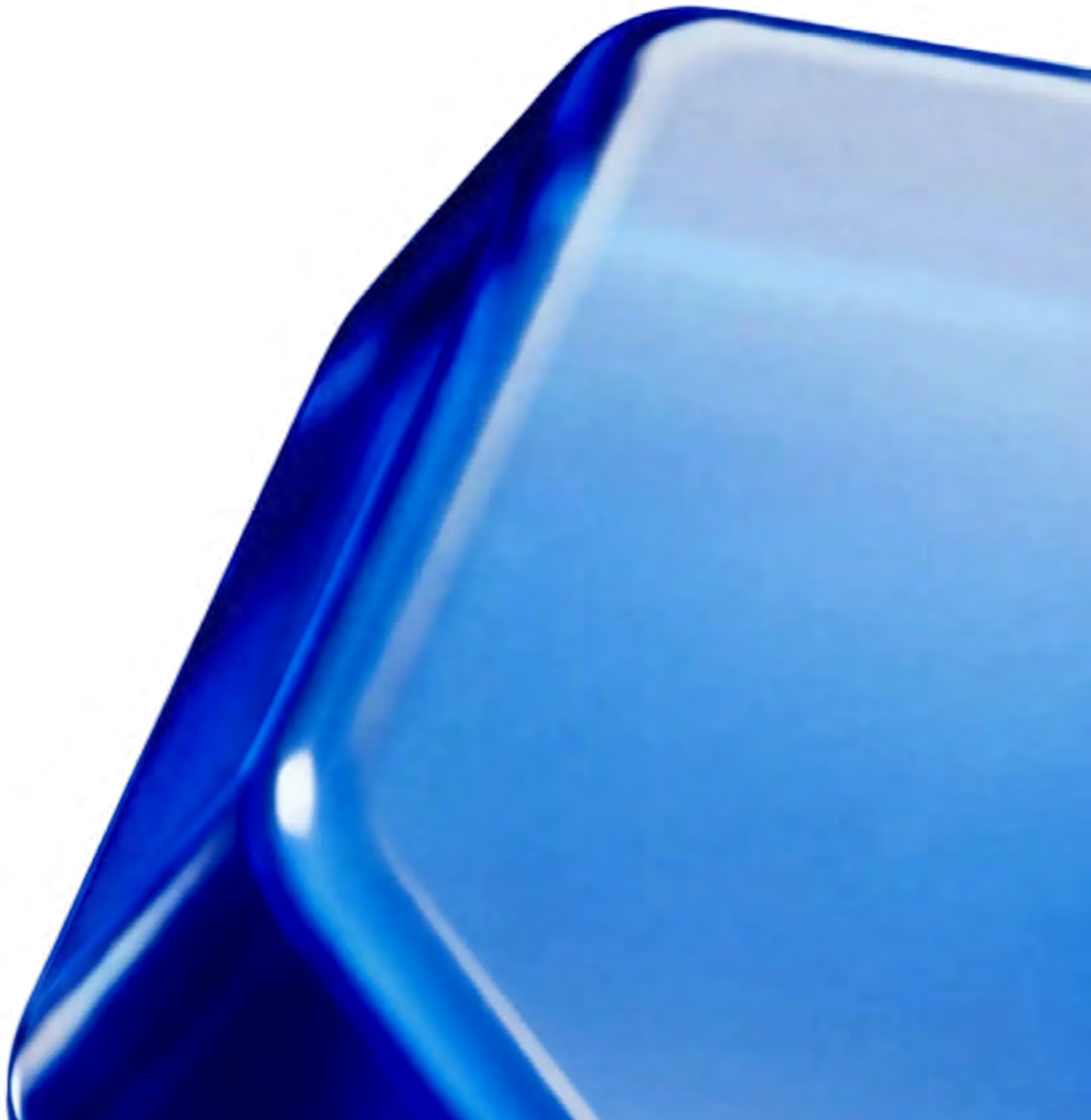
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Aaron Whitley

Senior Systems Engineer, outsourcing company, 51-200 Employees

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Why Customers Choose Azure Databases for AI

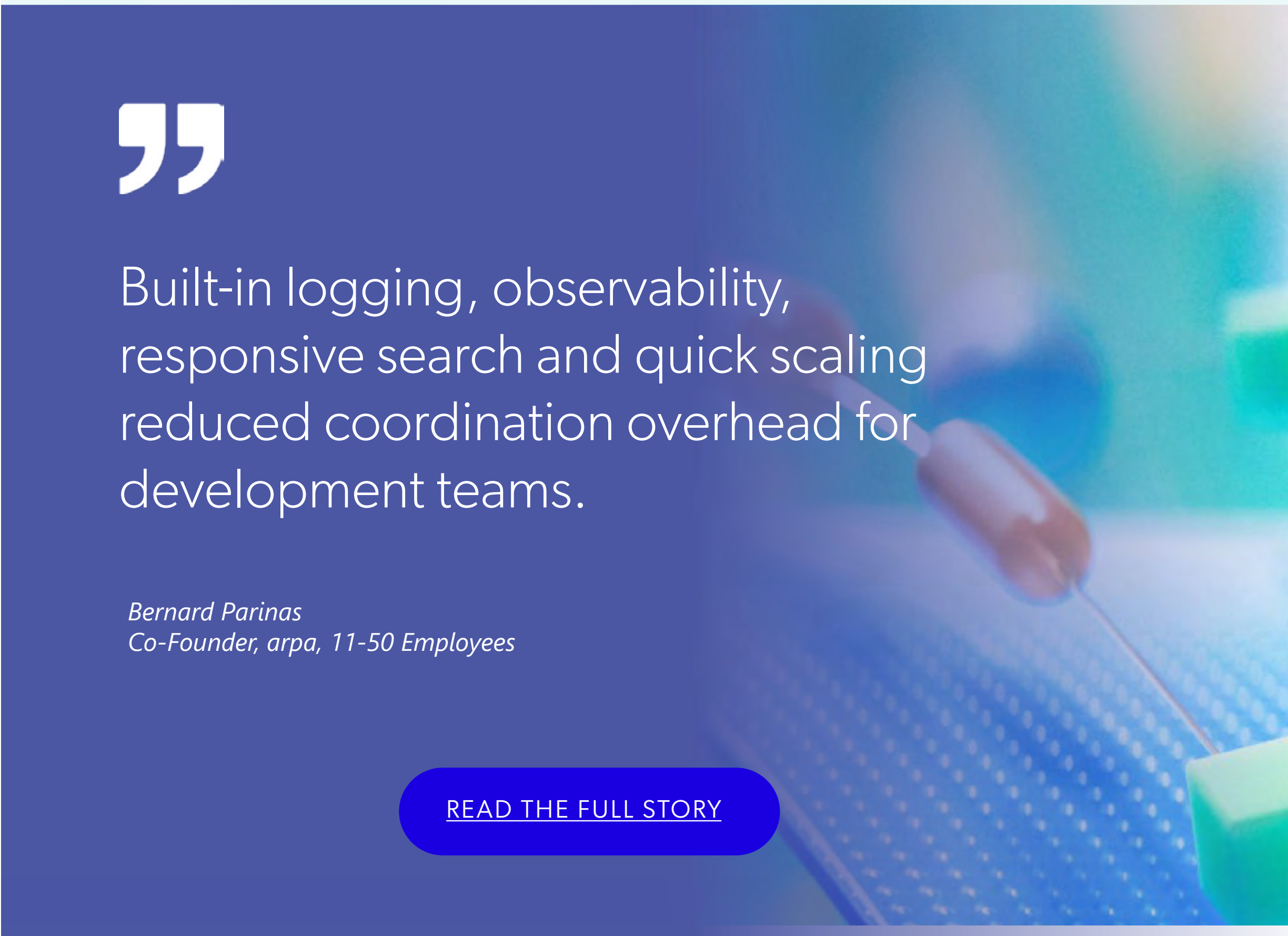


Competitive Differentiation Through Data Strategy

In evolving AI markets, database choice often determines competitive positioning. Companies that can iterate faster on AI features, deploy globally without latency penalties and integrate new AI capabilities without architectural rewrites maintain advantages that compound over time.

Risk Mitigation in AI Investments

AI projects carry inherent technical and business risks. Database platforms that reduce these risks – through managed service reliability, compliance certifications and supplier stability – enable teams to focus resources on differentiated AI capabilities rather than infrastructure concerns.



> Built-in logging, observability, responsive search and quick scaling reduced coordination overhead for development teams.

Bernard Parinas
Co-Founder, arpa, 11-50 Employees

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Strategic Platform Alignment

The decision to standardise on Azure databases often reflects a broader strategic commitment to Microsoft's AI ecosystem. Companies investing in Azure OpenAI, Foundry Tools or Foundry find that database integration multiplies the value of these investments by reducing overhead and enabling more sophisticated AI architectures.





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Managed Azure SQL reduced routine maintenance and supported governance through policies and vulnerability scanning.

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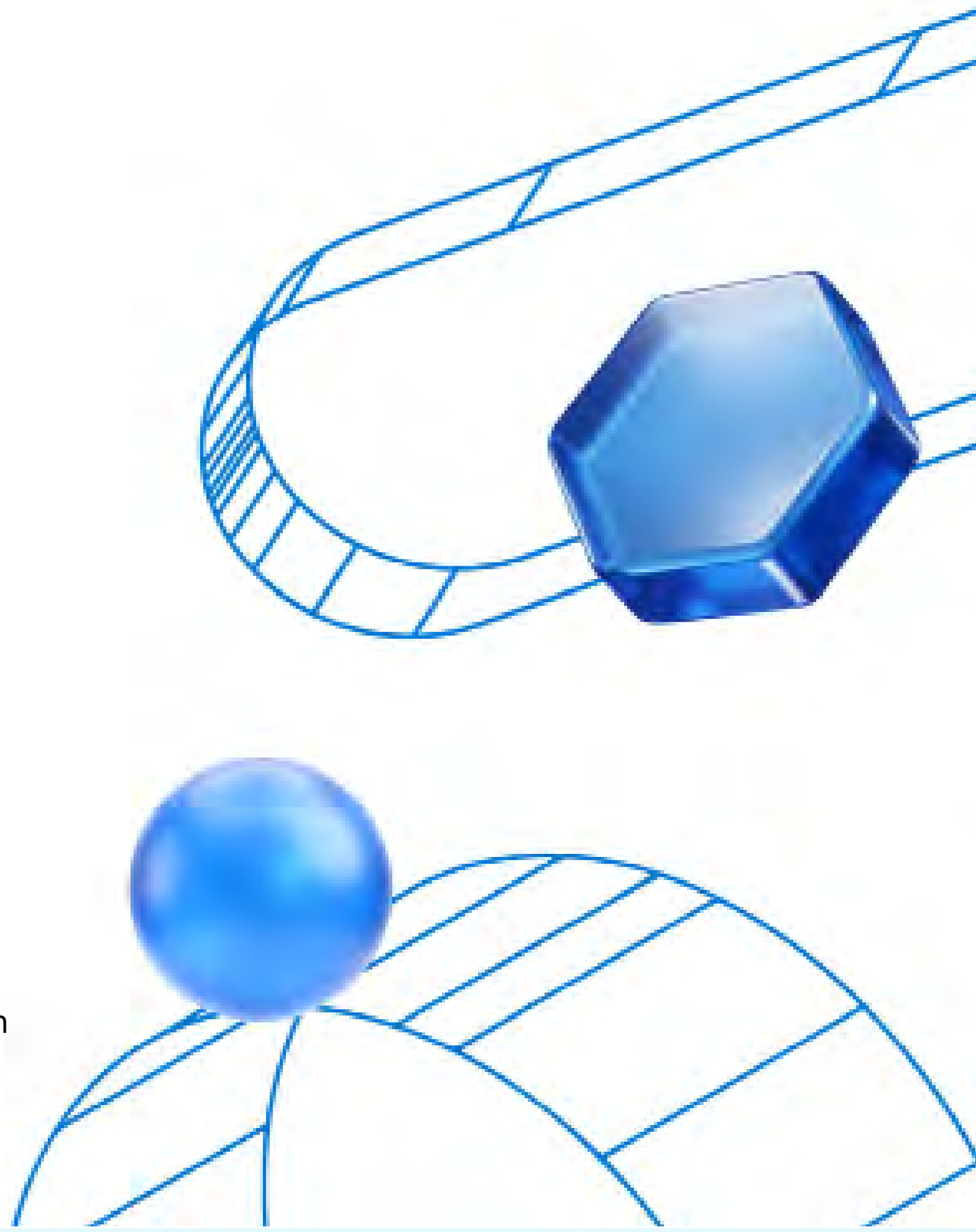
Kamil Konderak

Senior Cloud Architect, manufacturing company, 5,001-10,000 Employees

Future-Proofing AI Application Development

Technology leaders choose Azure databases not just for their current capabilities, but for Microsoft's commitment to AI innovation. The platform's ability to add new AI capabilities – from emerging model types to novel search algorithms – without requiring application rewrites provides a hedge against rapid AI evolution.

What distinguishes Azure's approach is the recognition that AI applications require more than just database functionality – they need an ecosystem of connected services. The integration between databases, AI services, development tools and global infrastructure creates a multiplier effect that individual capabilities cannot achieve alone. This ecosystem approach explains why developers often report faster AI implementation cycles and better production outcomes when building on Azure's database foundation.



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Global replication, straightforward deployment and autoscaling improved reliability and operational efficiency.

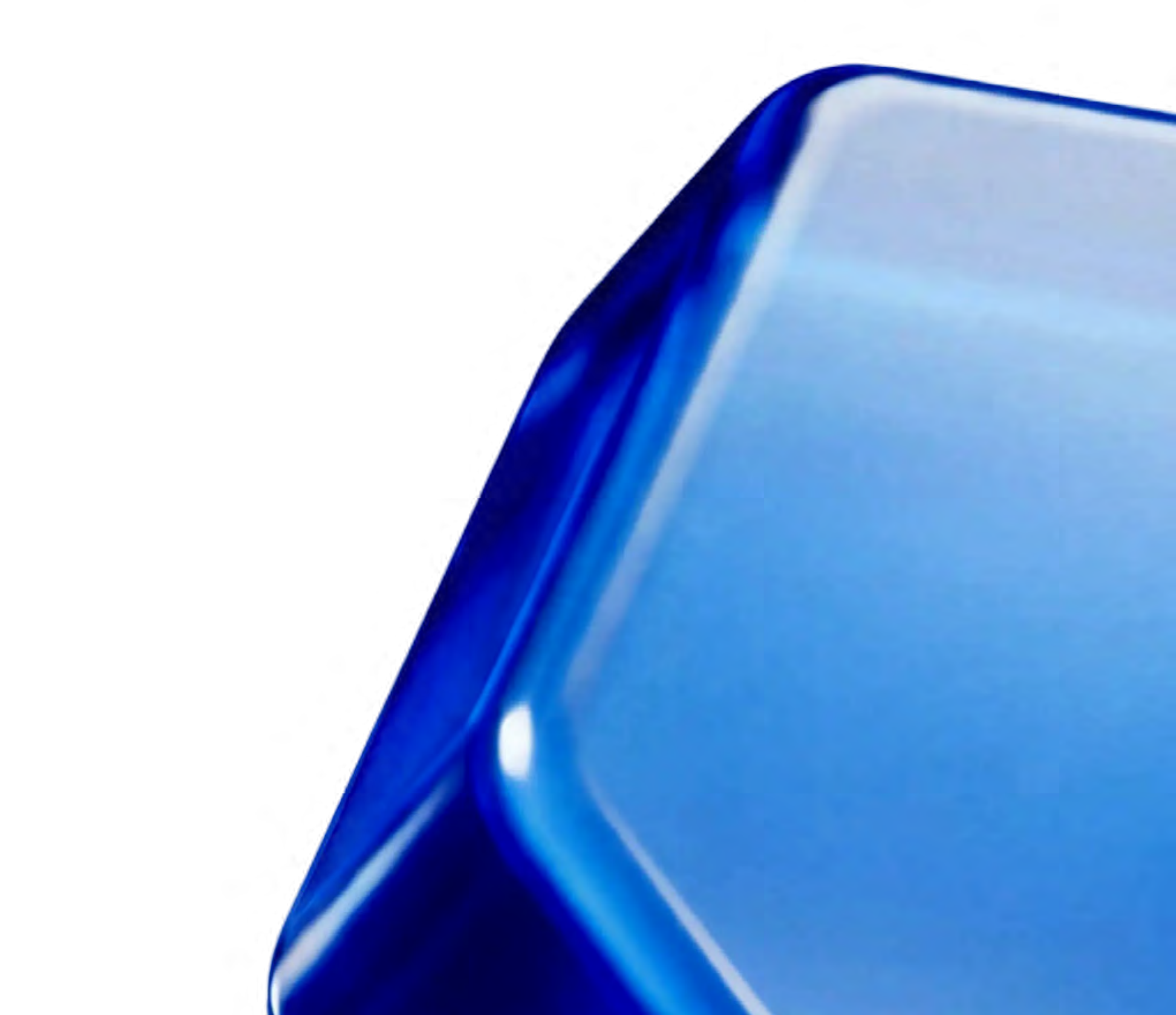
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Fabien Gouineau

Architecte Cloud, Visiativ SA, 1,001-5,000 Employees

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Conclusion



Azure's Operational Database Portfolio Is Uniquely Positioned to Support Real-World AI

Azure's database portfolio provides AI developers with purpose-built platforms that combine operational reliability with advanced AI capabilities. Rather than forcing developers to choose between traditional databases and AI-specific tools, Azure databases integrate both within unified platforms.

Each database platform serves specific AI application patterns while maintaining compatibility with Azure's broader AI ecosystem. This approach ensures developers can choose the best database for their particular requirements while still accessing consistent AI capabilities across the platform.



Customers see success through ease of use, innovation velocity and scalable intelligence

PeerSpot user testimonials consistently highlight three key advantages of Azure databases: simplified development processes, accelerated time-to-market and the ability to scale AI applications globally. These benefits are the result of Azure's integrated approach to AI and database services.

Developers report significant reductions in development time and infrastructure complexity, enabling them to focus on building innovative AI features rather than managing database operations.

Choose the Right Engine for the Right Job – and Bring AI to Life Faster

The key to successful AI application development is found in matching database capabilities to specific use case requirements:

Azure Cosmos DB is built for applications requiring global distribution, automatic scaling and integrated vector search capabilities. It's ideal for RAG applications, real-time personalisation and event-driven AI systems.

Azure Database for PostgreSQL provides the best solution for teams that prefer an open-source database while requiring enterprise reliability. It's optimised for intelligent, AI-powered applications, with native AI capabilities integrated directly into the database layer. These capabilities include vector search, Azure AI extension, LangChain integration and AI Agents support.

Azure SQL Database best serves enterprise applications requiring familiar SQL interfaces, regulatory compliance and integration with existing Microsoft tooling. It's optimal for adding AI capabilities to traditional enterprise systems.

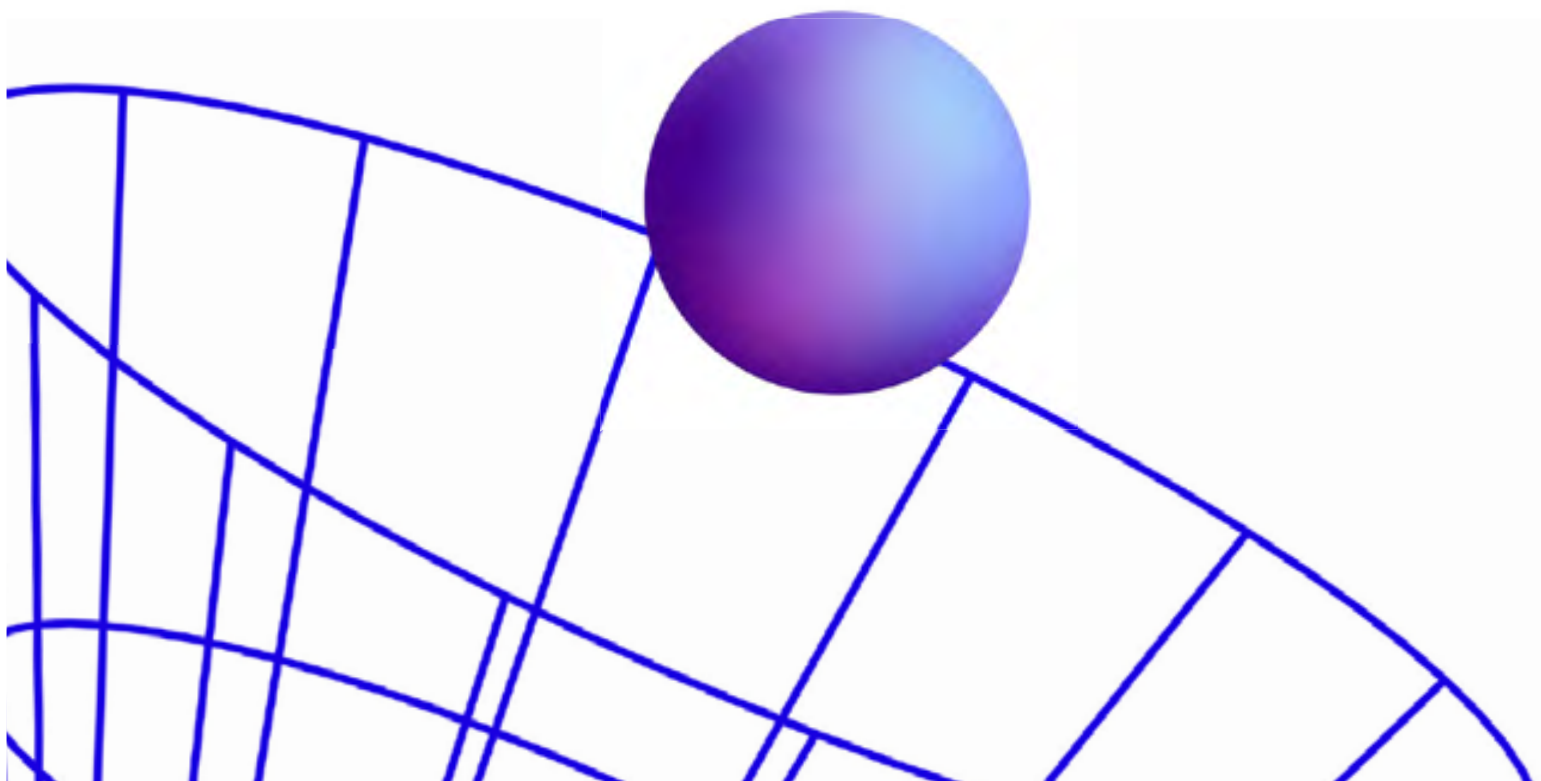
All three platforms share common advantages: built-in AI capabilities, seamless integration with Foundry Tools, managed service benefits and the ability to handle both operational and AI workloads within unified architectures.

The future of AI application development lies in platforms that reduce the traditional boundaries between operational databases and AI infrastructure. Azure's database portfolio provides a trusted, integrated foundation, helping developers build intelligent applications that scale globally while maintaining the reliability and consistency required for production systems.

By choosing Azure databases for next-generation AI applications, developers gain access to proven platforms that accelerate development cycles, reduce infrastructure complexity and deliver global scalability.

Modernise the data layer first: choose the right Azure database for each workload, connect it to Azure AI services and design for security, resilience and sovereignty from the start so AI applications can move from pilot to production with confidence

The testimonials and experiences shared by users on PeerSpot demonstrate the practical benefits and real-world successes that teams achieve when building AI applications on Azure's database foundation.



Fuelling AI Innovation: Build and Scale Applications and Agents with Azure AI-Optimised Databases

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